

DESCARTES'
DISCOURSE ON METHOD

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DESCARTES' DISCOURSE ON METHOD

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'AFTER men have been teaching and studying philosophy, upon divers principles, for these three thousand years together, there starts up a little fellow in a corner of the world, who changes the whole face of it, and undertakes to show, that all those who went before him understood nothing of the principles of nature. Wherein there is something more than empty boasting. For it must be acknowledged that this new philosopher gives us more light into natural things, than all the other together. Nevertheless, how happy soever he has been, to discover the weakness of the principles in the common philosophy; he has left in his own some obscurities, which the wit of man cannot clear up.'

(*Discourses, translated from Nicole's Essays,*
by JOHN LOCKE, pp. 56, 57.)

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PREFACE

THE *Discourse on Method* is generally looked upon as the introduction to Descartes' philosophy as elaborated in his later writings. This, although 'formally', is not 'materially' true. Both *Meditations* (epitomized in *Discourse 4*) and *Principles of Philosophy* (which is only a modified edition of the suppressed *Monde* described in *Discourse 5*) are in reality prior to the *Discourse* as a whole, while its concluding chapter, the sixth, rounds off the preceding account of Descartes' aims by an exposition of the difficulties he found in their execution. The *Discourse* is thus both a history and a criticism of Cartesianism as it presented itself to its author. It is a retrospect, a summing up of a life's achievement, rather than the laying down of a programme. Although Descartes' first published work, it is in effect his last.

The *Discourse* is therefore the primary document for the understanding of Cartesianism, and I have sought to use it as such. For its interpretation I have profited from the standard commentary of M. Gilson (as well as from his other books), and I have learnt much from the writings of such other recent French scholars as I have been able to study.¹

¹ See the select bibliography in Mr. S. V. Keeling's recent *Descartes* (Oxford University Press, 1934), and the exhaustive survey of the whole literature, grouped round the principal problems involved, by Prof. F. Olgiati, *Cartesio*, Milan, 1934. The striking volume of M. Ch. Serrus, *La Méthode de Descartes et son application à la Métaphysique* (Alcan, 1933), reached me too late for use. I am glad to find in it confirmation of my view that the

After their admirable work there are no new facts to adduce. I can only hope to suggest an emphasis which may be novel. Historically, the point at issue is that of the nature and fate of Cartesianism; but there is involved the whole problem of the value of the mathematical outlook and the general competence of the mathematical mind.

The book was seen in manuscript by Mr. J. S. Bentwich, Professor H. Bergmann, and Professor J. L. Stocks, and my thanks are due to them for their encouragement and comment. Some pages of chapters 1, 7, and 8 are taken from material which appeared originally in *Mind* and are reproduced by kind permission of the Editor.

JERUSALEM,
April 1937.

L. R.

originality of Descartes lies in the logic, the theology of the *Meditations* being a relapse: our estimates of the value of the logic would seem, however, to differ.

CONTENTS

I. INTRODUCTION: THE *DISCOURSE* ON METHOD AND THE CARTESIAN REVOLUTION I

§ 1. The *Discourse on Method* a turning-point in European thought. § 2. The Cartesian 'revolution' the attempt to substitute a physics based on metaphysics for a metaphysics based on physics. § 3. Cartesian science practical in aim. § 4. Its novelty (and problem) the treatment of physics as a part of mathematics. § 5. The importance of the narrative of the *Discourse*.

II. THE LITERARY HISTORY OF THE *DISCOURSE* 13

§ 1. The publication of the complete volume of *Discourse* and *Essays*. § 2. Its component parts: (a) *Meteors*; (b) *Dioptric*; (c) *Geometry*; (d) Preface. § 3. The contents of the *Discourse* and its 'real' date. § 4. Descartes' own order of his philosophical inquiries.

III. THE BACKGROUND OF THE *DISCOURSE* 28

§ 1. The significance of the order of Descartes' philosophical inquiries as given in the *Discourse*. § 2. Omissions in Descartes' narrative. § 3. The complexity of his character glossed over: Descartes and Pascal. § 4. Descartes and Pascal akin both in temperament and history. § 5. The spiritual emergence of Pascal. § 6. The spiritual emergence of Descartes: (a) the indecision of 1618; § 7. (b) the 'vision' of 1619; § 8. (c) the 'mission' of 1628. § 9. The poetic strain in Descartes and its repression in Cartesianism.

IV. THE NATURE OF THE METHOD 50

§ 1. The method typical of philosophical 'rationalism': the *Discourse* and the *Novum Organum*. § 2. The characteristics of Bacon's method. Its two negative rules. § 3. Its three positive rules. § 4. Descartes' four rules in the *Discourse* and their relation to the *Regulae*. § 5. The debt of the Cartesian method to dialectic and the connexion between dialectic and geometry. § 6. The key-note of the method the rule of 'division' and the unilateral 'order'.

V. THE WEAKNESS OF THE METHOD . . . 72

§ 1. The sixth chapter of the *Discourse* Descartes' conscious retrospect on Cartesianism as he saw it himself. § 2. The relationship between philosophy and science, and Descartes' aim in science. § 3. The method, abstract: science, concrete. The problem of limitation. § 4. The parallel criticism ten years later in the *Author's Letter*. § 5. The constant appeal to 'experiences'. § 6. The inadequacy of the method to Descartes' purpose.

VI. THE ECLIPSE OF THE METHOD . . . 91

§ 1. Descartes not always faithful to the method himself. § 2. His disastrous linking of it with his physics. § 3. The dissociation effected by his critics; Father Daniel's satire. § 4. The *Voyage du Monde* primarily an attack on Descartes' physics. § 5. The author's comparative estimate of the various elements of Cartesianism. § 6. Cartesianism no longer a system of physics or metaphysics but a general method of analysis: Christiaan Huyghens' notes to Baillet's *Life*. § 7. Huet's *Censura*: the merit of Descartes' writings in inverse proportion to their mathematical treatment of their various subject-matters. § 8. Other attempts to return to Aristotle, and the Lockian 'revolution'.

VII. THE SURVIVAL OF THE METHOD . . . 114

§ 1. Locke a Cartesian although rejecting both Descartes' metaphysics and his physics. § 2. Locke and Cartesianism in 1671. § 3. The delayed publication of the *Essay on Human Understanding* and Locke's study of Descartes. § 4. The 'chain' theory of demonstration and the possible influence of Newton. § 5. Locke's translation of Nicole: 'men know almost nothing'. § 6. Locke and Descartes on the nature and value of method.

VIII. CONCLUSION: THE PROBLEMS OF THE METHOD . . . 131

§ 1. Pascal's general criticism of Descartes. § 2. His particular criticism of the geometrical method. § 3. The geometrical ideal useless, especially in physics, § 4. and so recognized by Descartes himself. § 5. Descartes and the ideal of science. § 6. Science and philosophy.

INDEX . . . 141